

Garbage Disposal Care Guide

Your garbage disposal is built to handle everyday food scraps — but it isn't indestructible, and it isn't a trash can. The food and non-food items below are the most common causes of disposal jams, drain clogs, and burnt-out motors. A little care at the sink keeps your kitchen running and avoids an avoidable repair.

1 Bones

Chicken, rib, or fish bones are too hard for the blades. They either jam the unit outright or get chewed into shards that lodge further down the line.

2 Stringy & fibrous produce

Celery, corn husks, artichokes, and squash strings wind around the blades instead of chopping, which stalls the motor and can burn it out.

3 Coffee grounds

Grounds don't dissolve — they settle into a wet, sand-like sludge that slowly narrows the drain line until it backs up.

4 Fruit & vegetable peels

Potato, onion, and citrus peels are thin and stringy — they wrap around the blades and stick to the chamber walls rather than grinding down.

5 Eggshells

The inner membrane clings to the disposal wall and blades, building up a gritty film over time that reduces grinding power.

6 Grease, oil & fat

It goes down as a liquid but cools and hardens inside the pipe — hot water and dish soap don't stop it from re-solidifying further down the line.

7 Pasta, rice & oatmeal

These keep absorbing water after they're ground up, swelling into a thick paste that packs the trap and pipe.

NON-FOOD ITEMS — NEVER, EVER

- **Paper towels, napkins & "flushable" wipes** — they don't break down; they wrap around the blades and ball up in the trap.
- **Plastic wrap, bags, produce stickers & packaging** — jams the blades and can crack the flywheel.
- **Glass, metal, bottle caps, utensils & jewelry** — destroys the blades and motor on contact.
- **Cigarette butts, matches & twist ties** — pass straight through and clog the drain line further down.
- **Sponges, scouring pads & rubber bands** — shred and tangle around the motor shaft, causing it to seize.
- **Medications & chemicals** — never disposed of down any drain; they contaminate the water system.

BETTER HABITS AT THE SINK

- Run cold water before, during, and for 15–20 seconds after using the disposal.
- Scrape plates into the trash — the disposal is for rinsing, not for bulk food waste.
- Cut larger scraps into small pieces and feed them in gradually.
- Let grease cool in a container and throw it in the trash instead of the sink.

COST OF AVOIDABLE DAMAGE

Garbage disposal jams, clogs, or burnouts caused by any of the items above are considered avoidable damage, not normal wear and tear. If a disposal or drain line failure is traced back to these items — including at the next move-out or maintenance visit — the repair or replacement cost will be billed to the resident.